English Language: Lexis and Structure

Quick revision for JAMB UTME

Concord (subject-verb agreement)

- Singular subject takes a singular verb: *The teacher is here.* Plural subject takes a plural verb: *The teachers are here.*
- Subjects joined by **and** are plural: *Tola and Ada are friends.* Subjects joined by **or / nor**: the verb agrees with the nearer subject.
- Collective nouns (committee, team, class) take a singular verb when seen as one unit.
- Each, every, either, neither, everybody, nobody take singular verbs.
- Subjects like *news, mathematics, physics, economics* are singular.

Tenses to watch

- Simple past for finished actions: *She went yesterday.* Present perfect for results now or unfinished time: *She has gone.*
- Do not mix tenses within a sentence unless time really changes.
- Use **since** for a point in time and **for** for a length of time.

Commonly confused words

Word pair	Meaning
affect / effect	affect = to influence (verb); effect = result (noun)
principal / principle	principal = head or main; principle = rule
stationary / stationery	not moving / writing materials
complement / compliment	complete something / praise
access / excess	entry / too much
lose / loose	misplace / not tight

Figures of speech

- **Simile**: comparison using like or as. **Metaphor**: direct comparison. **Personification**: human qualities given to things. **Hyperbole**: deliberate exaggeration. **Irony**: saying the opposite of what is meant. **Oxymoron**: two opposites together (*deafening silence*). **Euphemism**: a gentler word for an unpleasant one. **Pun**: play on words.

Oral English

- Vowels: 12 pure vowels and 8 diphthongs. Silent letters: *knife, hour, psychology, island*.
- Stress: nouns and adjectives often stress the first syllable (*PREsent*), verbs the second (*preSENT*). Emphatic stress marks the word the speaker wants to stress.
- Rhyme: words rhyme when the vowel sound and following sounds match, whatever the spelling (*though / go*).

Comprehension and summary

- Read the questions first, then the passage, then answer in your own words. Summary: pick main points only, drop examples, write in full sentences.
- Idioms mean something different from the words: *to kick the bucket* = to die.

Exam tip: When two options both look right, read the sentence aloud in your head. The correct choice sounds natural.